court, was made his ataliq – his guardian. In 1602, the year that Salim marched to Etawah, Khusro acquired another powerful backer when he married Akbar's milk brother Aziz's daughter. Between them, his uncle and his father-in-law would lobby for Akbar's favourite grandson to pass over his own father to the throne.

A tense, often tragic endgame had begun to play itself out between the various contenders for Akbar's empire – and most tragically of all, its first casualty was Abul Fazl.

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Akbar was perfection for his historian. As Harbans Mukhia explains it, the idea of *insan-i-kamil*, a 'perfect man', was developed by a philosopher called Ibn al-Arabi to describe a 'millenary appearance on earth at God's command. Muhammad, for Ibn al-Arabi, was the exemplary Perfect Man; Akbar was for Abul Fazl'.[26] There is a mirrored perfection, too, in Abul Fazl's unshakeable devotion to his lord. Sent away from his desk to the Deccan, the historian was as committed to winning battles for Akbar as he had been to composing his life in praise. Salim might have thought he was rid of the scribe, but Abul Fazl rose, instead, 'from rank to rank of confidence and intimacy'.[27]

Salim, meanwhile, was falling further from grace by the day: 'As the ways of the prince were displeasing to [Akbar] and he continually went counter to his father's wishes, his father's neglect of him was increasing daily.' So writes Inayatullah, who completed the *Akbarnama* after Abul Fazl's demise. Inayatullah is clearly biased against Salim, but the facts indicate that he wasn't far off the mark.[28] It was in 1602 that Salim made his tentative march towards Agra; and in 1602 that Akbar raised Abul Fazl to the rank of 5000, sent him 'a swift special horse' for Nauroz and 50,000 rupees for his campaigns. Soon afterwards, he also sent him a farman: Akbar needed his friend and adviser back in court.

Back in Allahabad from his failed coup, Salim heard the news with apprehension. Abul Fazl, he would write some years later, was forever disparaging him. It is said that the writer had taken to calling Salim the 'King of Allahabad',[29] no doubt the kind of snide remark that so annoyed the prince. Salim was convinced that Abul Fazl must be 'prevented from